

The Lighthouse at Saltmarsh Point

The Lighthouse at Saltmarsh Point

by Mara Ellison

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For the keepers of small lights.

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Prologue

The tide went out at dawn, as it had every morning since 1887, and nobody in Saltmarsh thought to watch it go.

By the time the fishing boats had cleared the harbour wall and the gulls had finished quarrelling over the scraps on the quay, and the baker had set out her first trays, and the schoolmaster had rung his cracked brass bell, and the postman had begun his slow climb up the hill with a sack of letters that were mostly bills, the lamp at the top of the lighthouse was still burning, pale and stubborn against the brightening sky, because the keeper who should have put it out was nowhere to be found.

It was the first time in thirty-nine years that the light had been left on.

Chapter 1: The Salt Road

Dr. Imogen Hale arrived on the 3rd of March, 1926, with two trunks, a bicycle and a letter from Mr. Abel Crane, the harbour master.

The letter promised a salary of £120 a year, a cottage, and—underlined twice—no visitors after dark.

"You'll want the Salt Road," said the carter. "It floods at high water, mind."

"Does it flood often?" she asked.

"Only twice a day."

She laughed, but he did not, and by the time she understood that he was being *perfectly* serious the cart had already turned for home.

The notice on the cottage door read:

KEEPER ABSENT

ENQUIRE AT THE HARBOUR OFFICE

She had packed for every emergency she could imagine, e.g., a broken lens, a flooded cellar, a failed generator, etc., and for none of the ones that

actually happened. That night she consulted the tide tables¹ twice before breakfast was even a possibility.

¹ The Salt Road is covered for roughly four hours around each high tide.

Chapter 2: Plan B

Plan A had been simple: find the missing keeper, relight the lamp, go home.

Plan B was Imogen's own invention, and it involved a rowing boat, a flask of tea with a slice of lemon for the Vitamin C, and the tide tables.

"No!" he cried. "Not the north channel. Nobody rows the north channel in March."

"Then what do you suggest, Mr. Crane?"

He rubbed his jaw. "I suggest... I suggest we wait for the ebb."

* * *

They waited. At 4:15 p.m. the water began to slide away from the causeway, and by five o'clock the Salt Road lay bare and shining, all 2.5 miles of it.

The Lighthouse at Saltmarsh Point

Day	High water	Low water
Monday	6:10 a.m.	12:25 p.m.
Tuesday	6:55 a.m.	1:05 p.m.

On the back of the table someone had written, in pencil, **do not trust Tuesday.**

About the Lighthouse

About the lighthouse itself there were three stories, and Imogen heard all of them in her first week.

The first said it was built in 1851 by King William IV's own engineer, which was impossible, since that king had died in 1837.

The second said the lamp had cost \$4,000, shipped in 1,250 pieces from a workshop in Paris, and that the man who assembled it kept a café on the quay until the day he died.

The third story was the one the children told. It said the keeper could speak to ships in any language, that he had once answered a Russian trawler with a cheerful "П р и в е т !" and a steamer bound for 東京 with a bow, and that only a naïve person would ask how.

Imogen wrote all three down in her notebook, under the heading *Unreliable*, and underlined the second.

Chapter 10: The Tenth Bell

The bell in the lamp room rang ten times at midnight on the 21st, although nobody had wound it since the 2nd.

"That makes ten," said Mr. Crane, who had been counting on his fingers. "It only ever rings nine."

"What happens on the tenth?"

"I don't know. Nobody's ever stayed to find out—"

The door at the foot of the stairs opened. Wet footprints crossed the stone floor, one after another, and stopped at the first step. Then a voice Imogen had never heard, but recognised at once from Chapter I of the keeper's own logbook, said, "You left my light on."

"Somebody had to," she said.

Epilogue

The keeper stayed until spring. He would not say where he had been, only that the journey had cost him exactly 39 years and one good pair of boots.

Dr. Hale left Saltmarsh on the 1st of May. She took the bicycle, one trunk, and the tide tables, which she never trusted again.

The lamp is still lit every evening at dusk. If you take the Salt Road at low water you can see it from the second milestone... and if it is a Tuesday, you should walk a little faster.

About the Author

Mara Ellison grew up beside a tidal causeway and has never fully trusted a timetable. She does not exist; she was invented for this test fixture.

Also by Mara Ellison

The Cartographer's Daughter

Nine Bells for Winter

A Field Guide to Fog